

SOCIAL CONTRACT

ERBIUM INDUSTRIES – SOCIAL CONTRACT

This document establishes the expectations, boundaries, and responsibilities we agree to follow while playing **Erbium Industries**.

Its purpose is to give everyone at the table a shared understanding of the kind of campaign we are playing, how we treat one another, how decisions are handled during play, and how problems are addressed when they arise.

This is a living agreement. The group may revisit it if the needs of the campaign or the people at the table change.

CAMPAIGN EXPECTATIONS

Erbium Industries is a grounded science-fiction campaign about people trying to survive, get home, and decide what they are willing to do along the way.

The setting contains dangerous labor, corporate exploitation, debt, coercive employment, surveillance, discrimination, denial of legal personhood, bodily control, religious and political institutions, violence, death, and systems that may treat people as property, resources, or liabilities.

The campaign may become serious, frightening, unfair, or emotionally difficult. It will also include humor, friendship, exploration, wonder, ordinary life, downtime, victories, and opportunities for the player characters to form meaningful relationships with one another and the people they meet.

Players agree to create characters who can participate in the premise and who have some reason to continue traveling and working with the other player characters.

Characters may disagree strongly. They may dislike one another, hold incompatible beliefs, make mistakes, or argue about what the group should do.

Those conflicts must still allow the players to participate together in the campaign.

No player is expected to make the most tactically optimal, morally perfect, or narratively convenient decision.

MORALITY

Erbium Industries will use Catholic moral teaching as the campaign's standard for questions of good, evil, moral responsibility, and the consequences of human action.

The campaign will concern itself with **temporal consequences**: the damage wrongdoing causes to people, relationships, communities, the person committing the act, and the world around them.

God will not be depicted as directly intervening in the events of the campaign, and the GM will not speak for God. Religious characters may sincerely believe, doubt, interpret events, or attribute meaning to their experiences, but any purported divine response or revelation will remain ambiguous or non-existent.

PLAYER CHARACTER MORALITY

Evil player characters are not permitted.

Player characters may at times *act* flawed, selfish, angry, prideful, cowardly, greedy, vindictive, dishonest, or tempted toward wrongdoing. He or she may make serious mistakes and may occasionally commit genuinely evil acts. *Such acts should remain exceptional developments* in the character's story and will carry appropriate temporal consequences within the fiction.

If a character develops a repeated pattern of knowingly and willingly committing serious evil, that character will require a meaningful course correction to remain appropriate for the campaign. If a meaningful course correction no longer makes sense for the character, that character should be retired from play.

Evil actions will not function as a reliable means of gaining an advantage without serious cost. An apparent short-term advantage may create consequences that become clear only later.

MORAL RESPONSIBILITY IN AN UNJUST WORLD

The Settled Systems contain institutions that may legally authorize exploitation, coercion, violence, denial of personhood, or other grave injustices.

Characters remain morally responsible for the choices they knowingly make within those systems.

NPCs may sincerely misunderstand what is right, participate in injustice through habit or fear, rationalize wrongdoing, or lack important information.

Knowledge, intention, freedom, pressure, and circumstances may affect moral responsibility when those distinctions matter.

When a moral question materially affects campaign adjudication, Catholic moral teaching will provide the standard used by the GM.

Substantial disagreements can be discussed outside active play.

CONTENT BOUNDARIES

Everyone at the table may establish limits on material they do not want included or described in detail. A boundary may be raised at any point in the campaign. Requests to stop a scene, reduce its descriptive detail, or fade material to black will be respected in the moment.

If a newly established boundary would substantially prevent the campaign from using one of its established premises or central subjects, the GM and player will discuss how the boundary can be accommodated and whether the campaign remains a good fit for that player. Nobody is required to justify why particular material makes them uncomfortable.

Below is a section for player write-ins regarding content boundaries

LINES

A *line* is material that will not appear in the campaign.

Lines:

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.....

.....

VEILS

A *veil* is material that may exist in the campaign, but must occur off-screen, fade-to-black, or receive a minimal description.

Veils:

.....

.....

ROMANCE/SEXUAL CONTENT

Romantic content is allowed but must remain restrained. **Affection that would be normally appropriate in public company may be portrayed normally.** Romantic or sexual activity *beyond that level* will fade to black or remain completely off-screen. Explicit sexual roleplay is *not* permitted.

Erotic description, pornography, fetish material, graphic sexual discussion, recurring sexual humor are outside the intended tone of the campaign.

Sexual behavior that is seriously immoral, exploitative, degrading, or disordered may exist in the setting when relevant, but it *will not* be presented for titillation, praised as desirable conduct, or made a focus of player participation.

PLAYER CHARACTER ROMANCE

Romance involving a player's character requires the consent of the involved player.

At any point, a player may decline, stop, or redirect a romantic interaction without having to provide an in-character justification.

Players should check with one another before deliberately developing romantic relationships between player's characters.

These consent requirements also apply to romantic interactions initiated by NPCs. The GM is subject to the same boundaries as everyone else at the table.

LANGUAGE

Profanity, vulgarity, crude sexual jokes, and other such crass language should be avoided or kept to a minimum.

Characters may be angry, frightened, coarse, hostile, or unpleasant without requiring graphic or vulgar dialogue.

Players should make a reasonable effort to apply the same standard to both in-character and out-of-character speech.

VIOLENCE/HORROR

Combat, injury, death, dangerous working conditions, war, corporate violence, and threats to one's bodily autonomy are expected parts of the campaign.

Extreme cruelty, torture, mutilation, sadism, graphic gore, and similar material will not be celebrated or lingered on for entertainment.

When severe violence is relevant to the story, it should be treated seriously and described only to the degree necessary for the scene.

Extreme violence committed by a player character may also carry substantial moral and temporal consequences.

A player may ask for violent or disturbing material to receive less description at any time.

SEX, GENDER, ANCESTRY, AND SETTING CULTURES

The Settled Systems contain ancestries and cultures whose biology, customs, family structures, or social expectations may differ substantially from ordinary human experience.

These elements should be portrayed according to the established setting.

For example, Fonqugons are an agendered ancestry. A player portraying a Fonqugon should represent that ancestry faithfully without turning the ancestry's biology into sexual content, a running joke, or an out-of-character ideological argument.

The people at the table remain responsible for following the standards of conduct established in this agreement while portraying fictional people whose experiences may differ from their own.

The same principle applies to fictional religions, political systems, ancestry customs, bodily differences, family structures, and other setting elements.

RELIGION

Religion may be treated seriously within the campaign.

The Star Dream, the Elect, religious institutions, sincere belief, doubt, religious corruption, and competing interpretations of revelation are important parts of the Settled Systems.

Players may portray characters whose religious beliefs differ from their own.

The campaign may depict corrupt religious institutions, false teaching, mistaken beliefs, hypocrisy, or abuse of religious authority where appropriate to the setting.

The campaign will not portray God directly or use the GM's narration to claim what God thinks, wills, condemns, forgives, or judges within the fiction.

PLAYER RESPONSIBILITIES

Players commit to the following expectations.

PARTICIPATE IN THE GROUP

Create and play a character capable of participating with the party.

A character may be difficult, argumentative, stubborn, frightened, or socially awkward.

A character concept should still leave room for the group to function.

"That's what my character would do" does not override the responsibility to participate in a cooperative game.

SHARE THE TABLE

Give other players room to speak, make decisions, roleplay, investigate, and solve problems.

Allow someone to finish their thought before responding.

Avoid competing for the floor through volume, repetition, interruption, or continued explanation after the person making the decision has understood the point.

Pay attention when another player has the spotlight.

OWN YOUR CHARACTER

Each player makes the final decisions for their own character.

Advice, tactical suggestions, rules reminders, and ideas are welcome when requested.

Brief unsolicited suggestions may occasionally be useful. But the ability to do this may be revoked by a player being made uncomfortable from repeated *unsolicited* suggestions.

Once the active player understands the relevant information and has made a decision, that decision belongs to them.

Players should avoid directing another player's turn or repeatedly arguing them into a different choice.

RESPECT OTHER PLAYERS' CHARACTERS

Do not decide another character's emotions, beliefs, reactions, relationships, or internal thoughts for them.

Do not pressure another player into playing their character according to your preferred interpretation.

A player may ask questions, offer observations, or discuss characterization outside the scene.

The final decision belongs to the player controlling that character.

LEARN YOUR CHARACTER

Players are expected to understand the core mechanics of their character and the abilities, actions, spells, equipment, and other options that come up regularly during play. Less frequently used options do not need to be memorized, but players should know where to find them.

Starfinder 2nd Edition gives players substantial control over character creation. When choosing an option, players are responsible for reading what it does and making a reasonable effort to understand how it works.

Questions are expected. **It is always better to ask when you are uncertain than to assume how something works and be disappointed when the rule works differently.** Asking questions before acting also gives the GM an opportunity to resolve uncertainty before it affects the scene.

When possible, think about your actions before your turn begins and review your character between sessions.

If a player repeatedly struggles with core mechanics that arise regularly during play, the GM and player will discuss what is causing the problem and determine what preparation or assistance would help between sessions.

TABLE RULINGS

Rules questions should normally be directed to the GM.

If another player knows the relevant rule, they may briefly provide it **only when asked directly.**

The GM may make a provisional ruling so play can continue.

A player who still disagrees may ask that the rule be checked during a break or after the session.

A provisional ruling may be corrected for future play.

MANAGE FRUSTRATION

Everyone will occasionally become frustrated by a ruling, encounter, another player's decision, misunderstanding, bad roll, or situation in the fiction.

Players should avoid turning that frustration into repeated grumbling, sniping, hostile jokes, sighing, arguing, or background commentary that affects the rest of the table.

If something is genuinely bothering you during play, raise the concern clearly once so it can be addressed. If it cannot be resolved quickly, continued discussion should wait until a break or after the session.

PROTECT EACH OTHER'S AGENCY

Significant actions against another player character require the affected player's participation in making that kind of conflict part of the game.

This includes:

- ♦ mechanical PvP;
- ♦ stealing important possessions from another PC;
- ♦ deliberately sabotaging another PC;
- ♦ coercive mental effects used against another PC;
- ♦ significant betrayal;
- ♦ deliberately preventing another PC from participating;
- ♦ similar actions that materially interfere with another player's control of their character.

Characters may threaten, distrust, argue with, or oppose one another without automatically escalating the disagreement into mechanical PvP.

GAME MASTER RESPONSIBILITIES

The Game Master commits to the following expectations.

RESPECT PLAYER AGENCY

The GM presents situations, NPCs, consequences, hazards, and the surrounding world.

Players determine what their characters think, feel, attempt, believe, and choose.

The GM will make a reasonable effort to respond to unexpected solutions without requiring players to discover a predetermined answer.

The GM may describe involuntary experiences such as dreams, intrusive thoughts, sensory impressions, instinctive reactions, memories triggered by events, or effects imposed by game mechanics. These experiences do not determine what a character voluntarily believes, chooses, says, or does unless an explicit game effect grants that degree of control.

ADJUDICATE FAIRLY

The GM will make rules decisions in good faith, apply them consistently, and listen to concise corrections when a player believes something has been overlooked.

The GM may make a temporary ruling to keep the game moving.

Mistakes will happen.

When a mistake is discovered, the GM will acknowledge it and determine how the rule will function going forward.

PROVIDE MEANINGFUL INFORMATION

When the characters would reasonably know information necessary to make a meaningful decision, the GM will make a reasonable effort to provide it.

Mystery, incomplete information, deception, uncertainty, and mistaken beliefs may still be part of the campaign.

RESPECT ESTABLISHED BOUNDARIES

The GM will respect the group's Lines, Veils, and other content boundaries.

The GM will respond when a player asks for a scene to stop, change, fade out, or reduce its level of detail.

DO NOT PUNISH OUT-OF-GAME DISAGREEMENT IN-GAME

Out-of-game disagreements, criticism, frustration, scheduling problems, or interpersonal conflicts will not be answered through punitive encounters, targeted character consequences, withheld rewards, or other in-game retaliation.

In-world consequences for in-world actions remain part of normal play.

MAKE ROOM FOR EVERYONE

The GM will make a reasonable effort to notice when a player is repeatedly being interrupted, spoken for, overlooked, or crowded out of play.

The GM may redirect the conversation or explicitly call on someone when necessary.

MAINTAIN THE CAMPAIGN'S MORAL FRAMEWORK

The GM will adjudicate morally significant actions according to the framework established in this agreement.

The GM will not use morality as an excuse for arbitrary punishment.

Consequences should arise from the nature of the action, the people affected, and the situation in the world.

RULES AND TABLE PROCEDURE

RULES QUESTIONS

A rules question should be handled briefly during active play.

A player may:

1. ask the GM for a ruling;
2. provide a relevant rule or citation **when the GM or active player asks for assistance**;
3. briefly explain why they believe a rule applies **when the GM has invited that discussion**.

If a player asks another player for help, a brief side conversation is fine so long as it does not disrupt play. Any information obtained this way remains advice; the GM makes the table ruling.

The GM then makes the ruling for the current situation.

Extended rules debate should wait until a break or after the session unless resolving the question immediately is necessary to understand the scene.

TACTICAL DISCUSSION

Players are encouraged to cooperate.

Useful tactical discussion includes sharing information, asking questions, and helping another player understand their options.

The player whose turn or decision is active retains control of the final choice.

Once they have understood the relevant information and chosen what they want to do, the table should move forward.

SPOTLIGHT

The active speaker or player should be allowed to finish.

When another player has a personal scene, character moment, major decision, or focused conversation, the rest of the table should give that scene appropriate space.

Players should avoid inserting themselves into every conversation merely because their character is physically present.

COMMUNICATION AND CONFLICT

ASK BEFORE ASSUMING

Misunderstanding will happen. When practical, ask what someone meant before deciding why they behaved a particular way. Always give people an opportunity to explain themselves and adjust their behavior.

ADDRESS PROBLEMS EARLY

If another player's recurring behavior is interfering with your ability to enjoy the game, address it before resentment accumulates.

You may speak with that person directly or ask the GM to help facilitate the conversation.

Concerns should focus on specific behavior and its effect on play.

Examples include:

- ◆ repeated interruption;
- ◆ directing another player's turn;
- ◆ hostile commentary;
- ◆ prolonged rules arguments;
- ◆ dominating roleplay;
- ◆ ignoring another person's boundaries;
- ◆ behavior that repeatedly causes someone to disengage from play.

THE GM AS FACILITATOR

The GM can:

- ♦ mediate a conversation;
- ♦ help people explain what happened;
- ♦ clarify expectations;
- ♦ identify misunderstandings;
- ♦ help the group determine a workable solution.

The GM cannot guarantee a solution to an interpersonal problem that never involves the other person.

The GM will not create passive-aggressive table rules, encounter designs, seating arrangements, or indirect punishments aimed at secretly correcting one specific player.

PRIVATE CONVERSATIONS WITH THE GM

Players may bring concerns to the GM privately.

The GM will treat personal information with appropriate discretion.

When a concern involves another player's recurring behavior, resolving the problem may eventually require discussing that behavior with the person involved.

If you need something you are about to share to remain confidential, say so before sharing it.

The GM will tell you whether they can agree to that limitation.

FEEDBACK

Players are encouraged to tell the GM when something worked well, something was confusing, or something interfered with their enjoyment.

The GM may also give players feedback about table behavior when necessary.

Feedback should identify behavior and consequences as specifically as possible.

Personal attacks are not useful feedback.

PERSISTENT PROBLEMS

If someone has been told that a behavior is creating a problem and the behavior repeatedly continues, the group should discuss it directly.

A long-running campaign does not require everyone to remain at the same table regardless of compatibility.

Participation in the campaign is voluntary.

SESSION ETIQUETTE

During sessions, everyone agrees to:

- ◆ arrive prepared to play when reasonably possible;
- ◆ give notice when they expect to be late or absent;
- ◆ respect the agreed start and end times;
- ◆ give the active player reasonable space to make decisions;
- ◆ avoid prolonged side conversations while someone else is speaking;
- ◆ keep unrelated phone or computer use from becoming disruptive;
- ◆ prepare for upcoming turns when possible;
- ◆ ask for a break when needed;
- ◆ return from breaks within a reasonable time;
- ◆ avoid repeatedly derailing the session with unrelated conversation.

Real-life obligations take priority over a game. If attendance or scheduling repeatedly becomes incompatible with the campaign's schedule, the group will discuss it directly.

CHARACTER RETIREMENT AND LEAVING THE CAMPAIGN

A player may retire a character when the character no longer fits the campaign, the player no longer enjoys playing them, or their continued participation would violate the expectations established in this agreement.

The GM may require a character to be retired when:

- ◆ the character has developed a sustained pattern of serious evil without meaningful course correction;
- ◆ the character can no longer reasonably cooperate with the party;
- ◆ the character repeatedly becomes a vehicle for violating established table boundaries.

Whenever practical, the player and GM should work together to give the character an appropriate conclusion.

Players may also leave the campaign.

Nobody is obligated to continue participating indefinitely in a game they no longer enjoy or cannot reasonably attend.

The group should handle departures directly and respectfully.

TABLE AGREEMENT

We understand that this document cannot anticipate every situation that may arise during a long campaign.

We agree to:

- ◆ communicate when something is interfering with our enjoyment of the game;
- ◆ listen when another person raises a concern about our behavior;
- ◆ make reasonable adjustments when possible;
- ◆ respect the boundaries established by the group;
- ◆ give one another room to play our own characters;
- ◆ address recurring problems directly;
- ◆ approach disagreements in good faith.

We understand that compatibility cannot always be created through rules alone.

Participation in **Erbium Industries** remains voluntary for both players and the Game Master.

By signing below, we agree to the expectations and boundaries recorded in this Social Contract.

SIGNATURES

GAME MASTER

Printed Name:

Signature: Date:

PLAYER

Printed Name:

Signature: Date:

PLAYER

Printed Name:

Signature: Date:

PLAYER

Printed Name:

Signature: Date:

PLAYER

Printed Name:

Signature: Date:

AMENDMENTS

Changes to this agreement will be discussed with the group before taking effect. Material changes will be recorded in the digital version of the Social Contract so everyone is working from the same agreement.